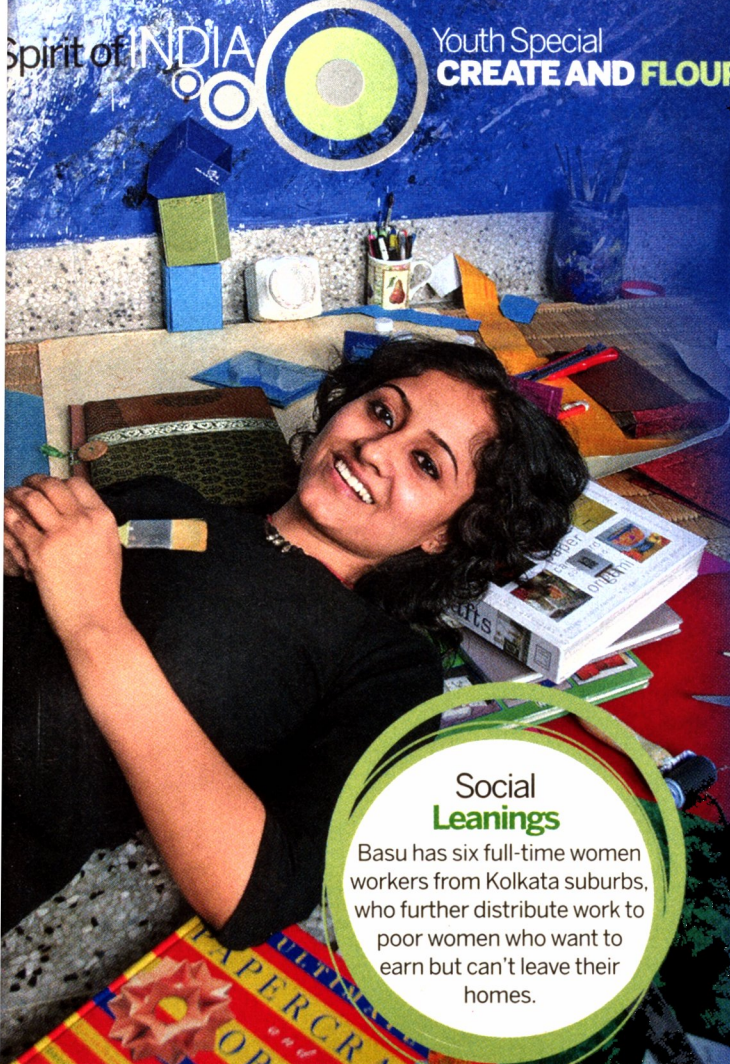




“LITERATURE AND ART CO-EXIST
in our products. I think this is
what people like the most.”

CHANDONI BASU, ENTREPRENEUR, 34

During the first week of the monsoon, a tiny shop in Kolkata's Kalighat turns blue. Even the store's customers are urged by Chandoni Basu's email to be dressed in shades of aqua for the *Brishti Saptaho* (rain week). It is just not a promotional gimmick for her shop, Aranya, in which every item is eco-friendly. It is also Basu's way of combining her love for nature and Bengali poetry to create a range of recycled products. She gives all her products finishing touches personally with a drawing, a sketch, or an abstract pattern. It was 10 years ago that Basu decided to quit sales promotion to make paper bags. "But I met with only negativity," she says. To make the paper bags attractive, she began drawing on them. Then, she came upon a brilliant idea. She took permission from all the contemporary poets of Bengal, and started writing snatches of poetry on her products. The response was overwhelming. Her shop now stocks visiting cards, papier mache albums, notebooks and lamp shades among other products, all made from recycled paper. Basu makes just enough to pay her bills. But then happiness can never be equated with money. **by Swagata Sen**

**Social
Leanings**

Basu has six full-time women workers from Kolkata suburbs, who further distribute work to poor women who want to earn but can't leave their homes.

SUVASHIS MULLICK

**“THE FIRST TIME I WENT
HOME AFTER BECOMING
AN ACTOR, SO MANY
people assembled out-
side my house that
one of the gates
came crashing
down.”**

**PARUL CHAUHAN,
TELEVISION ACTOR, 21**



Ask Parul Chauhan where she stays and she's likely to answer, "on the sets". Between playing one of the main leads on Star Plus' *Sapna Babul Ka Bidaai*, and Sony's *Jhalak Dikhlata Hai*, she has been sleeping for barely an hour everyday. "But I have no complaints. I've gone through a lot," she says. A revenue officer's daughter, Chauhan grew up in the small town of Lakhimpur Kheri in Uttar Pradesh. "My grandmother was unhappy when I was born. I was a girl and I was dark," she says. But a chance meeting with a cousin's friend changed everything. "He told me I should model as I was tall." It took 11 months of auditions to get that fateful call from Rajan Shahi, *Bidaai*'s producer. It's been two years since she took on the character of the dark-skinned Ragini, but Chauhan still shudders when she thinks about her days as a struggler. "I was ready to go back but my mother had given me all her savings. I had to prove myself." Within three months of *Bidaai* going on air, the show became Star Plus' golden goose. With fame came fortune. And Chauhan, whose parents had struggled to make ends meet, knew her hard earned money would first be spent on them. She bought her father a WagonR and now wants to upgrade it to Honda CRV. And before she buys herself a house in Mumbai, she wants "to build a bungalow for my parents in Lucknow". **by Jhilmil Motihar**

**Luck by
Chance**

Chauhan didn't audition for *Bidaai* but had dropped her pictures at the production house and was called for a look test. The shoot began within 15 days.

SHRIYA PATIL
SHINDE